# Conversations about Home (at a deportation centre) and Rigged Game

By Warsan Shire and Dylan Garity

## INTRODUCTION

*A new report from the Center for Immigration Studies has determined that as of October 2014, one out of every five U.S. residents doesn't speak English in their home. The new data shows that the number of people who speak a language other than English has reached an all-time high of 61.8 million with the largest increases from 2010 to 2013 being speakers of Spanish, Chinese, and Arabic.*

*Statistics are great, but the stories behind the statistics often get overlooked. Why are so many speakers of other languages coming to America? Perhaps we should take a moment to consider the homes from which they fled. Conversations about Home (at a deportation centre) by Warsan Shire.*

Well, I think home spat me out, the blackouts and curfews like tongue against loose tooth. God, do you know how difficult it is, to talk about the day your own city dragged you by the hair, past the old prison, past

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the school gates, past the burning torsos erected on poles like flags? When I meet others like me I recognise the longing, the missing, the memory of ash on their faces. No one leaves home unless home is the mouth of a shark. I've been carrying the old anthem in my mouth for so long that there's no space for another song, another tongue or another language. I know a shame that shrouds, totally engulfs. I tore up and ate my own passport in an airport hotel. I'm bloated with language I can't afford to forget.

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They ask me *how did you get here?* Can't you see it on my body? The Libyan desert red with immigrant bodies, the Gulf of Aden bloated, the city of Rome with no jacket. I hope the journey meant more than miles because all of my children are in the water. I thought the sea was safer than the land. I want to make love but my hair smells of war and running and running. I want to lay down, but these countries are like uncles who touch

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you when you're young and asleep. Look at all these borders, foaming at the mouth with bodies broken and desperate. I'm the colour of hot sun on my face, my mother's remains were never buried. I spent days and nights in the stomach of the truck, I did not come out the same. Sometimes it feels like someone else is wearing my body.

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I know a few things to be true. I do not know where I am going, where I have come from is disappearing, I am unwelcome and my beauty is not beauty here. My body is burning with the shame of not belonging, my body is longing. I am the sin of memory and the absence of memory. I watch the news and my mouth becomes a sink full of blood. The lines, the forms, the people at the desks, the calling cards, the immigration officer, the looks on the street, the cold settling deep into my bones, the English classes at night, the distance I am from home. But Alhamdulilah all of this is better than

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the scent of a woman completely on fire, or a truckload of men who look like my father, pulling out my teeth and nails, or fourteen men between my legs, or a gun, or a promise, or a lie, or his name, or his manhood in my mouth.

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I hear them say, *go home*, I hear them say, *f***** immigrants, f***** refugees*. Are they really this arrogant? Do they not know that stability is like a lover with a sweet mouth upon your body one second and the next you are a tremor lying on the floor covered in rubble and old currency waiting for its return. All I can say is, I was once like you, the apathy, the pity, the ungrateful placement and now my home is the mouth of a shark, now my home is the barrel of a gun. I'll see you on the other side.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Warsan Shire***
***Book: Teaching My Mother How to Give Birth***
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## TRANSITION

*The lucky families who are not deported and are allowed to stay in America have the luxury of healthcare and education. Education . . . . but often only in English, not their native language. For example, In 2002, Massachusetts residents voted to replace transitional bilingual education with an English-only curriculum, which meant that English as a Second Language teachers are no longer allowed to help students with their native language in any way. Yet the students are still expected to perform at grade level by the end of the school year. Dylan Garity, whose sister is an ESL teacher concludes that "Even with the best resources available, it's impossible for these students to achieve those standards." – not only is it an affront to basic human rights . . . . It's a Rigged Game by Dylan Garity*

### RIGGED GAME

Every day when I was five, my older sister would play
teacher.
Her students were me, my stuffed rabbit and an

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American girl doll,
She'd line us up at the end of the bed and teach us
whatever she'd learned in school that day.

Now, she teaches ESL at an elementary school in Boston
and every week she tells me stories about her students.
Ana does not know how to read in Spanish, much less
English
but she still wants to be a writer when she grows up.
Juan chooses to stay inside and study at recess so that
one day he'll be able to teach his own brother.

These kids are good organs in a sick body.
In 2001, No Child Left Behind
gutted bilingual education.
Students who have been in the country for one year
are now expected to perform at grade level
on standardized English tests.
My sister is not allowed to instruct them in Spanish.
If the kids don't jump high enough, the school loses
money

EDUCATIONAL

Improving a school by picking its pockets
is like tuning a guitar by ripping off the strings.

Learning to read in a new language
before you can even read in your own
is like learning to walk while a pit bull is chasing you.
Like learning to sing with the conductor's fist down your throat

This year, for my sister's birthday,
I bought books for her students.
A poem on one page in Spanish, the next in English.
She is not allowed to help them read the first.
Their heritage is a banned book

Learning to read in a new language
when you can't even read in your own
is like trying to heal a burn victim by drowning them.
We are telling these children
who have spent their whole lives in the deep end
that they'll learn how to swim if they just float out a little farther.

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In the 1980s, American slaughterhouses
began building corrals in curves,
so no animals could see the blood at the end of the track.
This is how we kept them moving forward.
In 2001, we began building the hallways of our schools in curves.
This is how we keep them moving forward.

You never learn, you fail the test
You never learn you fail the test
You never learn, you drop out.

I know, I am lucky enough to be one of the winners of this game
I was handed a head start
and a rulebook in my own tongue

but the winners of a rigged game
should not get to write the rules.

On the television,
some senator preaches that throwing money
at an "urban school" is like feeding caviar to your dog.
They just won't know how to appreciate it
After all, if these parents can't take care
of their own children, why should we?

Well tell that to Ana
who has my sister translate newsletters aloud to her father
because he, too, was never taught how to read

Tell that to Juan
whose mother and baby sister are still in Guatemala
whose father works three jobs

My sister tells me school is the most stable place in these kids' lives.
She has been a teacher since she was smaller than they are.
but since when does being a teacher mean having to
swear not to help?

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Since when does being a teacher mean having your hands tied
as the schoolhouse burns to the ground?
We are leading these children along a track built in circles
as their lungs fill with smoke
telling them it is their fault
they can't find a way out

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Dylan Garity***
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